

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Great Fire of London

Year 5 reading comprehension · Information text · 13 marks · About 25 minutes

A city of wood

In 1666, London was a crowded city of narrow streets and wooden houses. Most houses were made of timber, and many were coated in tar to keep out the rain. The buildings were so close together that their upper floors almost touched. It had also been a long, dry summer. In a city like this, one small spark could be disastrous.

The fire begins

In the early hours of Sunday 2 September, a fire started in a baker's shop in Pudding Lane. The baker, Thomas Farriner, and his family escaped, but the flames spread quickly. A strong east wind carried sparks from house to house, and soon the fire was out of control. The streets were so narrow that people could not easily escape with their belongings, so many fled across the River Thames by boat.

Fighting the fire

People tried to stop the blaze with leather buckets and hand-held water squirts. Soldiers and citizens pulled down houses with hooks to make gaps, called firebreaks, which the flames could not easily cross. At last, the wind dropped, and the fire died down by Thursday 6 September, four days after it began.

What was lost

Around 13,000 houses and 87 churches were destroyed, including the great St Paul's Cathedral, and tens of thousands of people lost their homes. Many families camped in open fields outside the city. Remarkably, very few deaths were officially recorded.

Rebuilding

After the fire, a new law said that houses must be built of brick or stone, and the architect Sir Christopher Wren designed a new St Paul's. The writer Samuel Pepys buried his wine and his cheese in the garden to protect them, and wrote about the fire in his diary, so we know a great deal about what it was like.

1. In which street did the fire start? (1 mark)

2. Give two reasons why the fire spread so quickly. (2 marks)

3. What are “firebreaks”, according to the text? (1 mark)

4. For how many days did the fire burn? (1 mark)

5. Why do you think the law was changed so that houses had to be built of brick or stone? (2 marks)

6. How do we know so much about what the fire was like? (1 mark)

7. Summarise the whole text in no more than three sentences. Cover how the fire started, the damage it caused and what happened afterwards. (3 marks)

8. The text says very few deaths were “officially” recorded. Why might the writer have used the word “officially”? (2 marks)

Writing task: Imagine you are a Londoner in 1666. Write a diary entry about the night the fire began.
